goodreads

A UI/UX Redesign Case Study

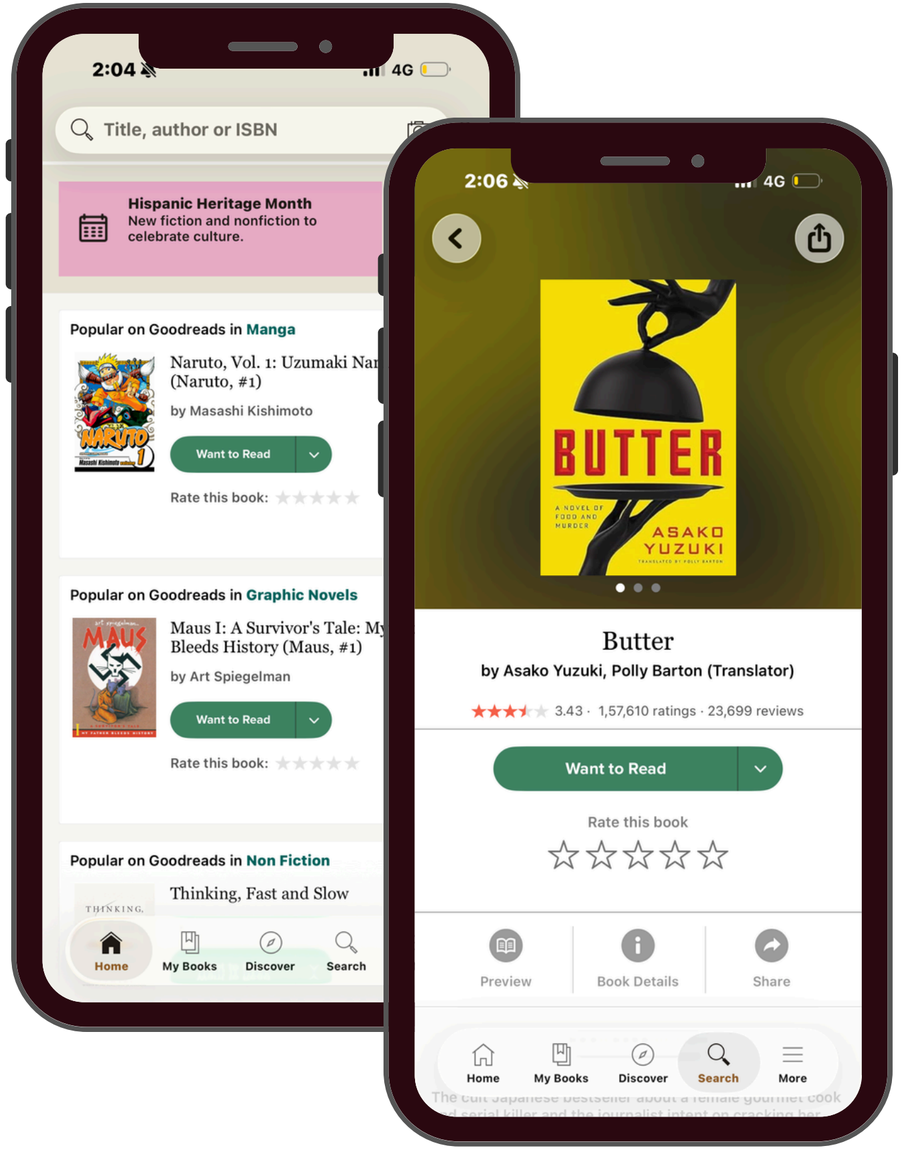
Interface Design

Aleesha K.L & Meha Senthilkumar

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About the App

Goodreads at a glance, what it is, who owns it, and how it works today

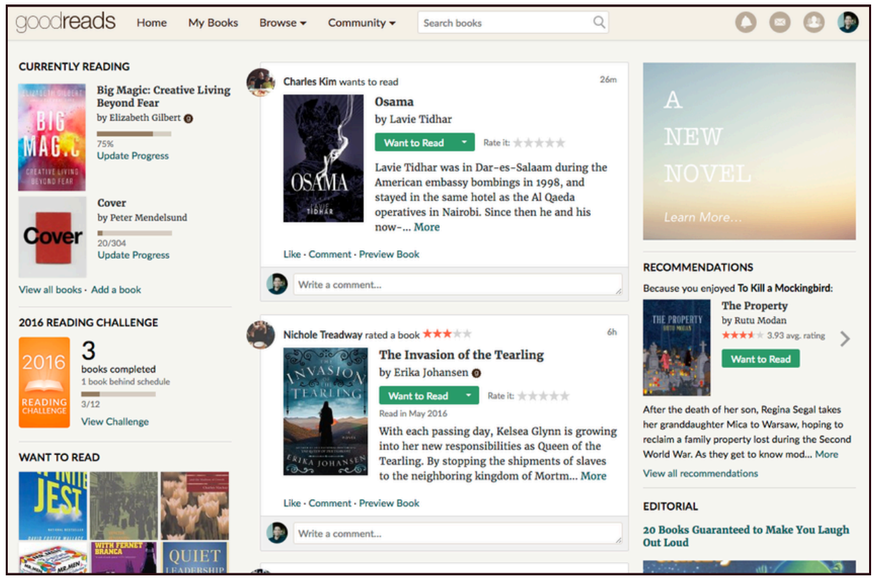


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What Is Goodreads?

Goodreads is the largest social cataloguing platform for readers, a place to log books read, rate and review them, follow friends, and get recommendations. Launched in 2007 and acquired by Amazon in 2013, it has grown into the default “reading resume” for millions of book lovers, even as its interface has stayed largely unchanged for over a decade.

#1	Brand recall among book apps in this study
69.6%	Of survey respondents recognise the brand



The world’s largest site for readers and book recommendations part social network, part personal library, part rating system.

Core Features Today

goodreads



Shelves & Cataloguing

Sort books into Want to Read, Currently Reading and Read, plus custom shelves and tags.



Ratings & Reviews

5-star ratings with long-form text reviews, sorted mainly by “most liked.”



Reading Challenge

An annual numeric goal (e.g. “read 20 books in 2026”) with a progress tracker.



Friends & Groups

Follow friends' activity feeds, join genre or author discussion groups.



Recommendations

Genre- and popularity-based suggestions, plus “Readers Also Enjoyed” lists.



Giveaways & Author Tools

Publisher-run giveaways and an author program for Q&As and updates.

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Secondary Research

What readers are already saying about Goodreads across app stores and the web

Secondary Research Methodology

Before running our own study, we reviewed publicly posted app-store reviews and web commentary on Goodreads to understand recurring pain points independent of our own sample. This grounded our survey questions in real, alreadyvoiced frustrations rather than assumptions.

1

Competitor; Platform Analysis

Studied Goodreads and competitor platforms to compare features, interfaces, and UX patterns.

2

Literature & UX Research

Reviewed researchpapers, articles, and UX case studies related to reading and book discovery apps.

3

User & Accessibility Research

Analysed user reviews, online discussions, and WCAG 2.2 guidelines to identify user pain points and accessibility needs.

4

Design Gap Identification

Used secondary findings to identify key design gaps and opportunities for the Goodreads redesign.

What Reviewers Are Saying

goodreads

Link to the reviews

Mateliuz ★★	*Barcode scans frequently mislabel books — wrong authors, mismatched covers, and descriptions in the wrong language make in-store lookups unreliable.*
Achuthan Baskaran ★★★	*Search often works only as literal keyword-matching rather than true semantic search, and the interface feels clunky compared to newer apps.*
Sara Garver ★★	*Tracking finished audiobooks is tedious and requires manual date edits instead of syncing automatically with listening apps.*
Zachary (Z) ★★	*The mobile app lags behind the website — profile and group edits made on desktop don't carry over, and progress tracking is inaccurate.*
Luke Dennison ★	*Reviews can't be filtered or sorted on mobile, only on desktop — and logging in via the website reverts back to the app, creating a dead end.*

Reviews on Goodreads App

goodreads

App Store Reviews

This app is awful... Jan 25
★☆☆☆☆ Preparedforit

I love the site but this app is absolute TRASH. There is no way of sorting the books you're looking through, and if you go to ANY list the top books are always the same....Hunger Games, Divergent, Harry Potter and the like.
Heaven help you if you're interested in the community feature at all, because that's next to useless.
You're also unable to search for genre or anything other than Title, Author, or BSN.
Just very disappointing overall.
And let's face it, the mobile site is no better...I had to switch to my laptop because every time I tried to navigate to a new page, it needed me to sign in AGAIN to my account. Over and over and over.
I've since uninstalled the app and will be reduced to having to use an actual desktop in order to access this site with any success.

Disappointing Jan 27
★☆☆☆☆ paulaliza

I honestly love the site and the concept for having a place to discover, rate and review books is life changing. However the app itself? Total garbage.

Worst app ever Dec 4
★☆☆☆☆ Slybetty

This app is terrible. The pits. And whenever I try to open the desktop version, it defaults to this awful app. Goodreads is a terrific concept - I'll stick with the desktop version (only accessible from my computer) from now on.

Google Play Reviews

Julia Federing
★★★☆☆ 4/4/19
this app is barely functional, even less so than it's iOS counterpart. you cannot change the edition of the book you are reading and the style of the app is not pleasing to the eye.

S sai ganesh
★★☆☆☆ 3/19/19
the app is not in sync with the website. so some updates don't show on the app. multiple features are not available. cant track lists. cant see reader stats. needs a lot of improvement.

Andere Martin
★★☆☆☆ 6/12/19
Is it just me or the options available through the app are VERY limited? I am not able to explore quotes nor groups and I can't find the Follow option for new authors... for now signing in through the browser itself seems a better and faster idea.

khalid alkatheeri
★☆☆☆☆ 3/19/19
compared to apply version this one is bad , you cant not see other languages of the book . you can't suggest any change even if the information written is incorrect . you can't brows the other versions and prints of the book like apple app . the app on app store is way better .

Mounica Srinivas
★☆☆☆☆ 7/5/19
i recently moved from iPhone to android but i realised this app has so many problems ,for example - cant see the editions of the book available, can't create a not exclusive shelf , the search is really bad , can't edit half of the things for a book . please fix it soon

goodreads

Unsatisfied User Experiences

The app is dated and filled with... Jun 16
★☆☆☆☆ osulls490

I understand that this is a social media platform for a dying medium, but the site still finds some fun ways to make discovering, engaging, and tracking your heading habits modern. I think it's time Amazon breathes some new life into the platform and especially their mobile apps.

Introduction of annoying... edited Nov 11
★☆☆☆☆ kristinafh

I'm a long time goodreads member. Since they have introduce ads into the iOS version, the UI experience has sucked beyond belief. I can't scroll down the screen in certain areas. I'm better off pulling up the site on safari.

Additionally, the site times out A LOT. And that's regardless of time of day and it doesn't matter if you access via this app or your desktop.

Buy more servers or do some load balancing.

Two thumbs 👎

Flawed User Experience Design Mar 28
★☆☆☆☆ rajivpant

As many other users have also said on the reviews here and on Reddit and other social media, this app has a very poorly designed user experience. This iPad app, the iPhone app, and the Android app are all low quality apps. There is no practically usable way to manage and reorder lists. Removing books from lists pops up a confirmation prompt each time and thus is very inconvenient to use for several books.

Unfortunately there are currently no popular alternatives for Goodreads. If there was one, I'd switch in a heartbeat.

Extremely User-Unfriendly 1y ago
★☆☆☆☆ JoshJack

They make this app more complicated and confusing that it needs to be. You want to add your own shelf? Good luck, it either won't add or won't be recognized when trying to add a book to it. Why won't more than two shelves show up on my shelf page? Why do I have to click into a second menu just to access them? Why when I try to add a book it lists shelves that don't even exist. It's terrible.

Reviews

morley greening

★☆☆☆☆ 2/18/19

While it has all the possibilities of becoming the new Facebook for book lovers, Goodreads has completely disregarded the social media aspect of bringing like minded people together. The lack of an ability to find and participate in groups is quite a fail, forcing people to do so only on laptops and PCs is an oversight that must be corrected. it's developers need to go back to the drawing board and correct these mistakes.

Kevin Shoesmith

★★★☆☆ April 27, 2019

It does what it's supposed to, and for that reason it gets a passing grade, but it desperately needs a design overhaul. It doesn't need to go overboard, but the current aesthetic is shabby and weak, like its creators aren't proud of it. The app icon is a perfect example: a brown, non-descript letter "g" on a beige, non-descript background. The whole presentation could simply be better.

Amanda Hendrickson

★★☆☆☆ May 6, 2019

Good for keeping track of books you have read but not good with anything else. I want to love this app but it is hard to use any of its other features other then scanning my book and personally rating it. Finding friends is hard, and just figuring out how to find what you are looking for is confusing. Honestly this app could be a lot better.

Key Findings from Secondary Research

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1 Simplified navigation

Make the app structure clearer and reduce the effort required to access important features.

2 Better Book Discovery

Improve search and browsing so users can find relevant books more easily.

3 Personalised recommendations

Use reading preferences and behaviour to provide more relevant recommendations and reduce decision fatigue.

4 Improved Social Interaction

Make reviews, ratings, discussions, and sharing easier to discover and interact with.

5 Better Reading Management

Make features such as reading lists, shelves, reading progress, and tracking more organised and intuitive.

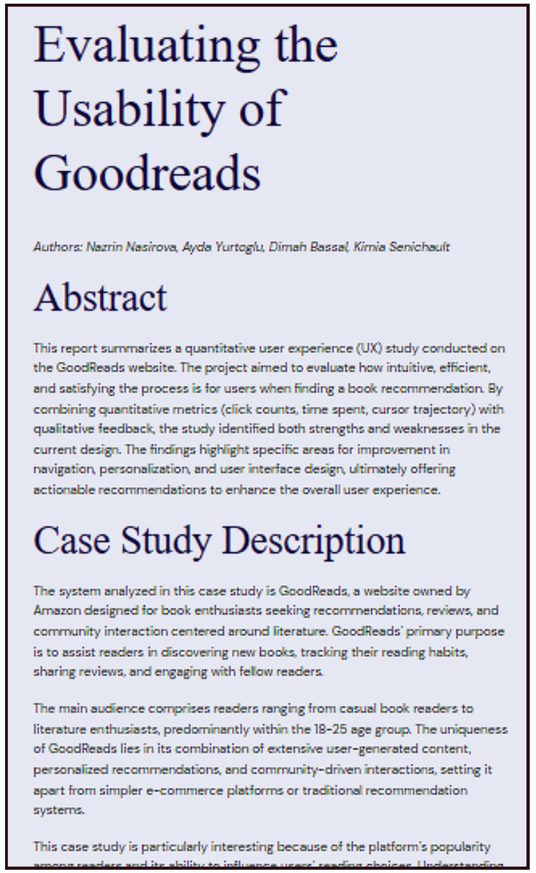
6 Accesible Interface

Follow WCAG 2.2 principles through readable typography, sufficient colour contrast, clear labels, consistent navigation, and accessible interactions.

Research Papers on Goodreads App

goodreads

Goodreads Usability Case Study



Evaluating the Usability of Goodreads

Authors: Nazrin Nasirova, Ayda Yurtoglu, Dimah Bassal, Kirnia Senichault

Abstract

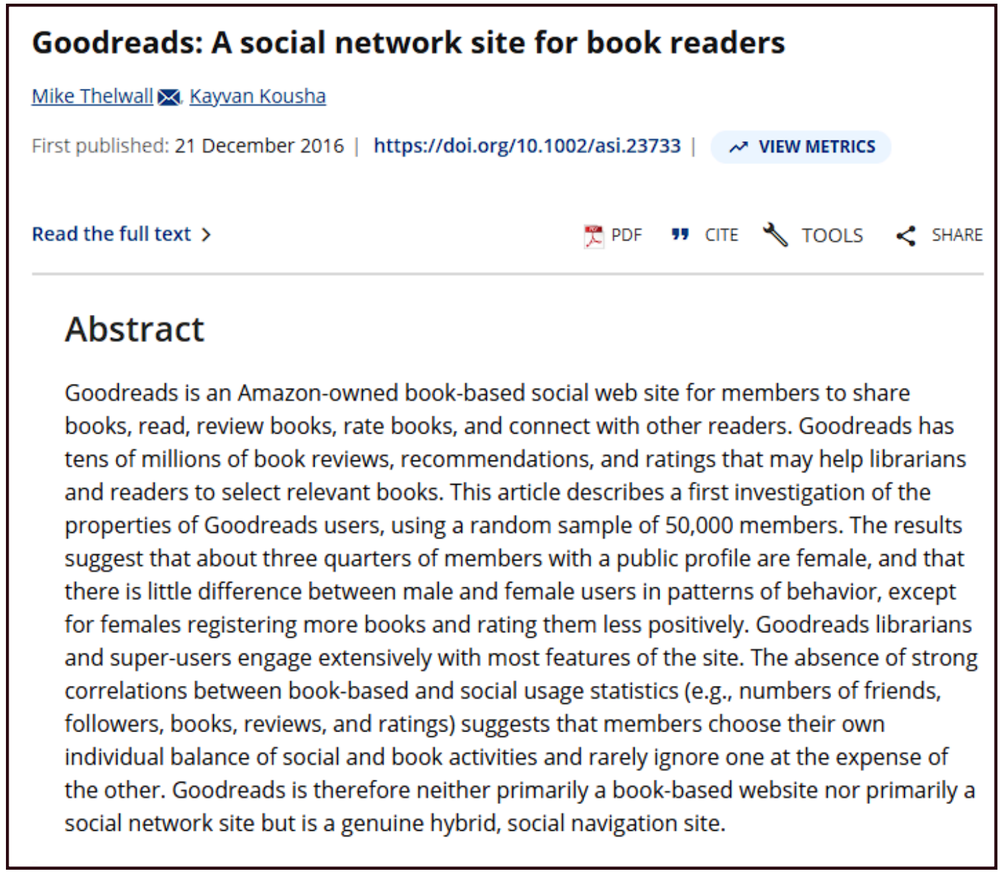
This report summarizes a quantitative user experience (UX) study conducted on the GoodReads website. The project aimed to evaluate how intuitive, efficient, and satisfying the process is for users when finding a book recommendation. By combining quantitative metrics (click counts, time spent, cursor trajectory) with qualitative feedback, the study identified both strengths and weaknesses in the current design. The findings highlight specific areas for improvement in navigation, personalization, and user interface design, ultimately offering actionable recommendations to enhance the overall user experience.

Case Study Description

The system analyzed in this case study is GoodReads, a website owned by Amazon designed for book enthusiasts seeking recommendations, reviews, and community interaction centered around literature. GoodReads' primary purpose is to assist readers in discovering new books, tracking their reading habits, sharing reviews, and engaging with fellow readers.

The main audience comprises readers ranging from casual book readers to literature enthusiasts, predominantly within the 18–25 age group. The uniqueness of GoodReads lies in its combination of extensive user-generated content, personalized recommendations, and community-driven interactions, setting it apart from simpler e-commerce platforms or traditional recommendation systems.

This case study is particularly interesting because of the platform's popularity



Goodreads: A social network site for book readers

Mike Thelwall, Kayvan Kousha

First published: 21 December 2016 | https://doi.org/10.1002/asi.23733 | VIEW METRICS

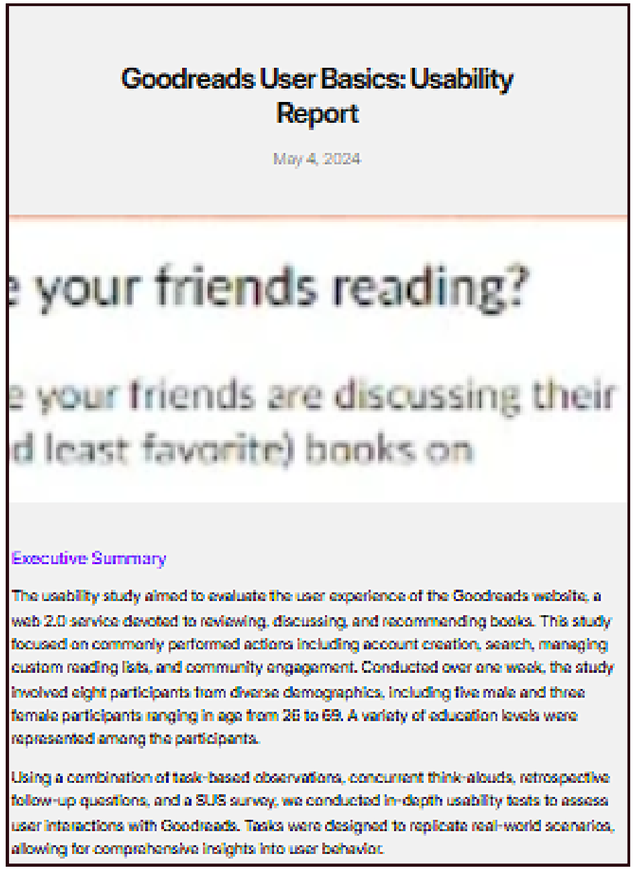
Read the full text > PDF CITE TOOLS SHARE

Abstract

Goodreads is an Amazon-owned book-based social web site for members to share books, read, review books, rate books, and connect with other readers. Goodreads has tens of millions of book reviews, recommendations, and ratings that may help librarians and readers to select relevant books. This article describes a first investigation of the properties of Goodreads users, using a random sample of 50,000 members. The results suggest that about three quarters of members with a public profile are female, and that there is little difference between male and female users in patterns of behavior, except for females registering more books and rating them less positively. Goodreads librarians and super-users engage extensively with most features of the site. The absence of strong correlations between book-based and social usage statistics (e.g., numbers of friends, followers, books, reviews, and ratings) suggests that members choose their own individual balance of social and book activities and rarely ignore one at the expense of the other. Goodreads is therefore neither primarily a book-based website nor primarily a social network site but is a genuine hybrid, social navigation site.

Research Paper – Wiley Online Library

Goodreads User Basics – Usability Report



Goodreads User Basics: Usability Report

May 4, 2024

e your friends reading?

e your friends are discussing their
d least favorite) books on

Executive Summary

The usability study aimed to evaluate the user experience of the Goodreads website, a web 2.0 service devoted to reviewing, discussing, and recommending books. This study focused on commonly performed actions including account creation, search, managing custom reading lists, and community engagement. Conducted over one week, the study involved eight participants from diverse demographics, including five male and three female participants ranging in age from 26 to 68. A variety of education levels were represented among the participants.

Using a combination of task-based observations, concurrent think-alouds, retrospective follow-up questions, and a SUS survey, we conducted in-depth usability tests to assess user interactions with Goodreads. Tasks were designed to replicate real-world scenarios, allowing for comprehensive insights into user behavior.

goodreads

Competitor Analysis

How Goodreads stacks up against the two apps readers mention most as alternatives

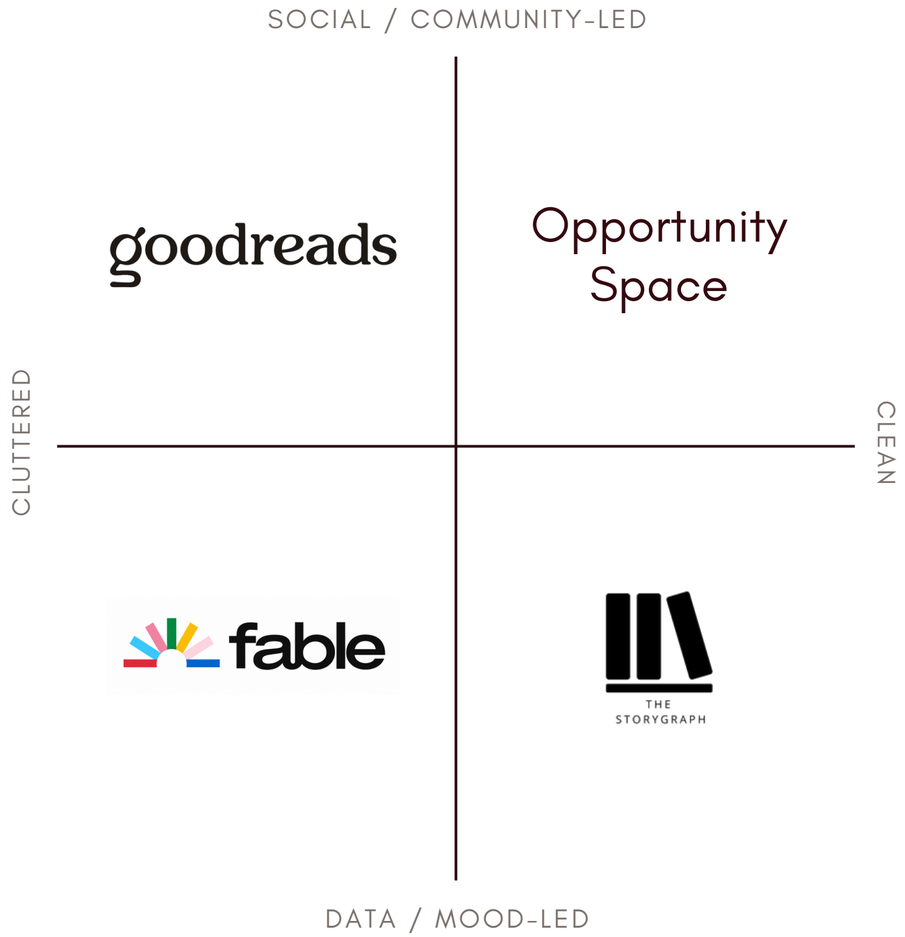
Goodreads vs StoryGraph vs Fable

goodreads

Competitors	Goodreads	The StoryGraph	Fable
Positioning	Social cataloguing & reviews	Data-driven, mood-based tracking	Social reading & book clubs
Owner	Amazon	Independent	Everand (Scribd)
Discovery model	Genre & popularity lists	Mood, pace & stats-based matching	Community feeds & club picks
Visual style	Dense, text-heavy, dated	Clean, chart-forward, dark mode	Social-media style, image-rich
Standout feature	Massive review database	Mood/pace charts, half-star ratings	Author & influencer-run book clubs
Known weakness	Cluttered UI, weak search, slow sync	Smaller review community than Goodreads	Best features often paywalled

Market Positioning Map

goodreads



Reading the map

Goodreads sits in the cluttered / social quadrant — strong on community, weak on clean data-driven discovery.

StoryGraph has claimed the clean + data-led corner. Fable owns social but with a lighter visual footprint.

The open space — clean, mood/data-aware, and still socially connected — is exactly what our survey respondents describe wanting.

goodreads

Heuristic Evaluation

Scoring the current Goodreads interface against Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics

Evaluation Method

goodreads

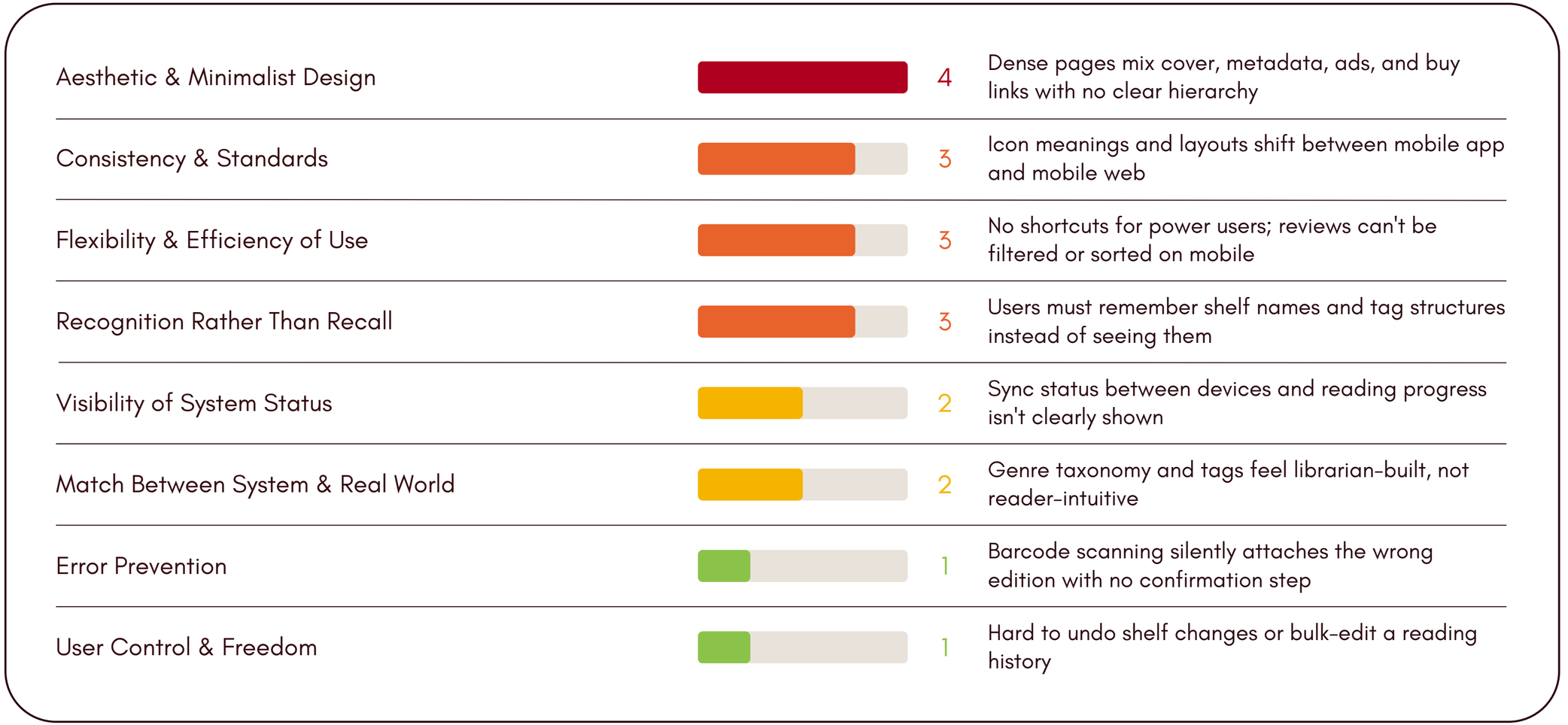
Two evaluators independently walked through core Goodreads flows — search, book detail, shelving, writing a review, joining a group — and scored each of Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics on a 0–4 severity scale, then reconciled findings against the secondary-research themes.



0	1	2	3	4
Not a problem	Cosmetic, fix if time allows	Minor, low priority fix	Major, important to fix	Catastrophic, must fix

Where Goodreads Loses the Most Points

goodreads



goodreads

User Study — Survey

Quantitative signal from 46 readers on habits, preferences and expectations

Survey Methodology

goodreads

We ran a structured survey covering reading habits, discovery behaviour, app-feature preferences and direct Goodreads feedback, then followed up with 5 in-depth interviews (next section) to add narrative context to the numbers.

51	69.2%	71.2%	17
TOTAL RESPONDENTS	AGED 18-24	STUDENTS	MAJOR GOODREADS USER

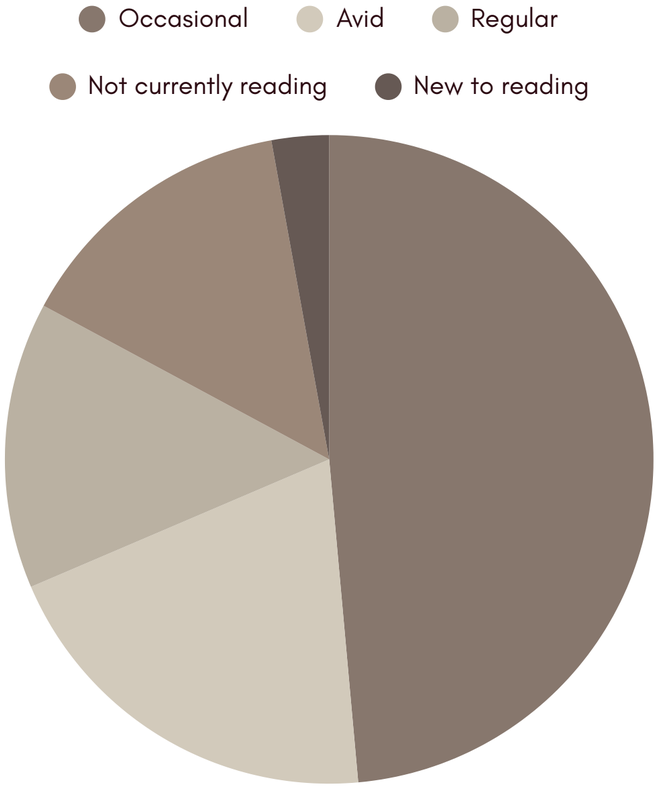
Sample skew to note: the panel leans young and student-heavy, which fits the primary target audience for a redesign but under-represents older or professional readers — a gap the interviews partly address.

Link to the User Research Survey

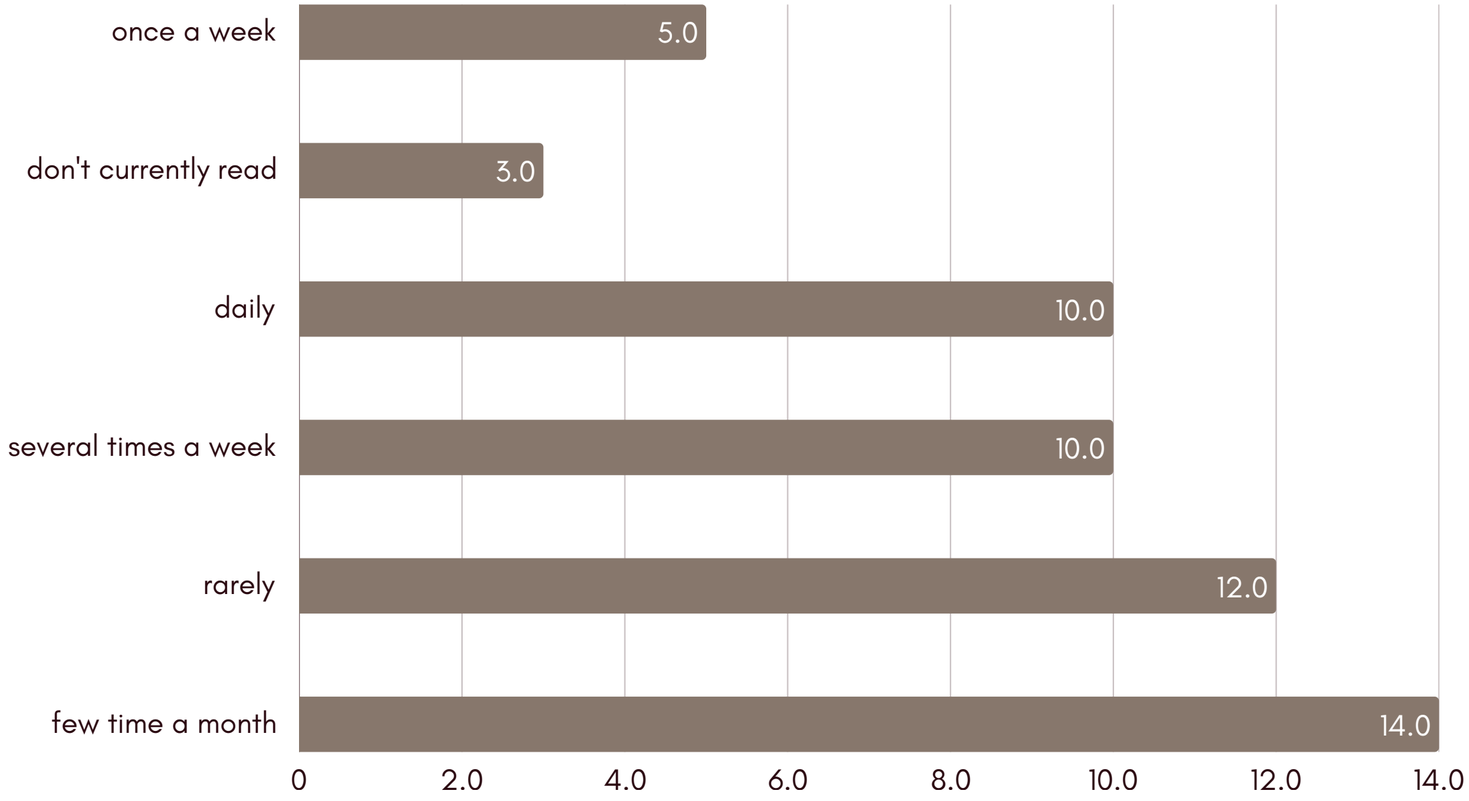
Who We Heard From

goodreads

Reader Type (of 51 logged responses)



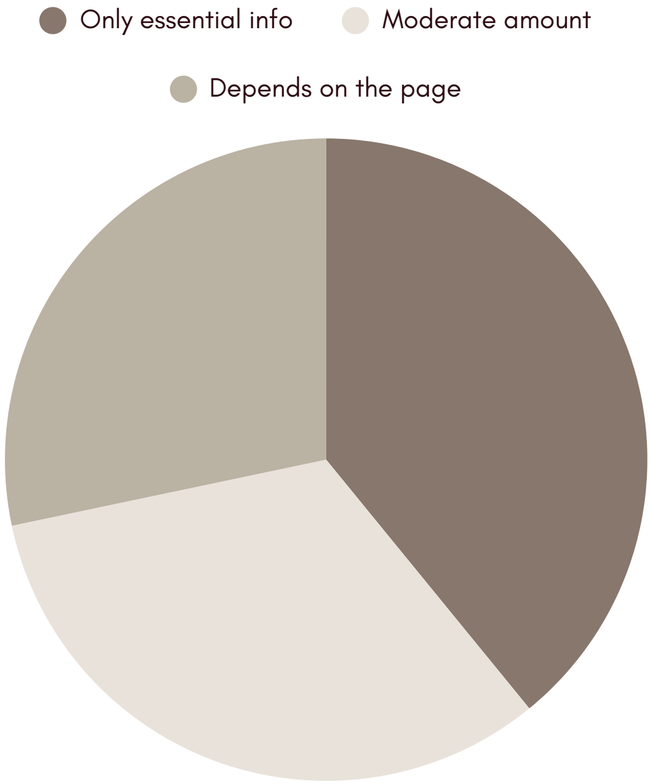
Reading Frequency (of 51 logged responses)



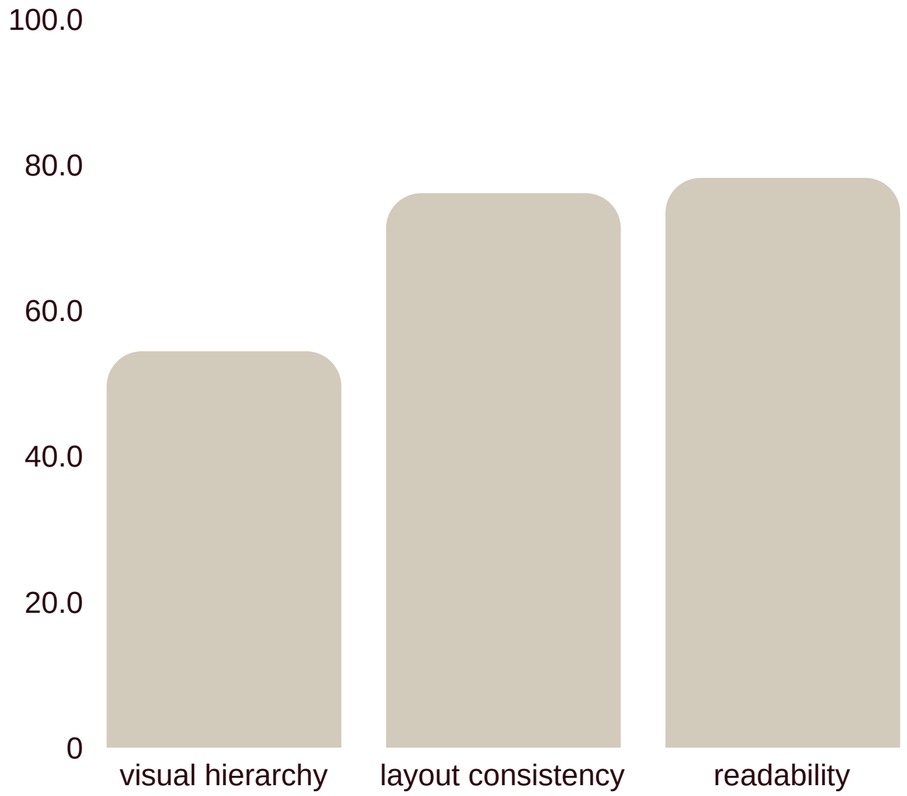
Screen Density & What Readers Value

goodreads

Information Density Preference (n=51)



Rated “Highly Important” (n=51)

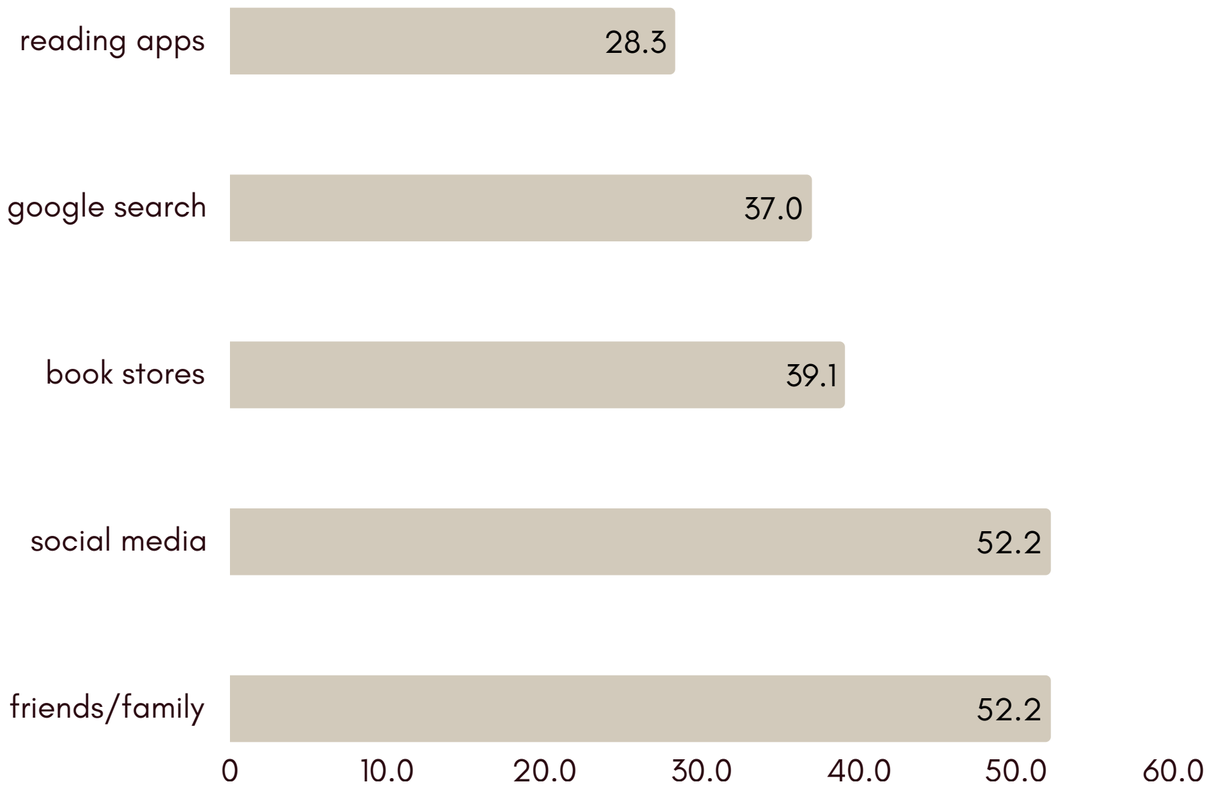


- Readability comes first for most readers.
- Consistent layouts and clear hierarchy make information easier to navigate.
- Users prefer balanced information density, avoiding both clutter and excessive emptiness

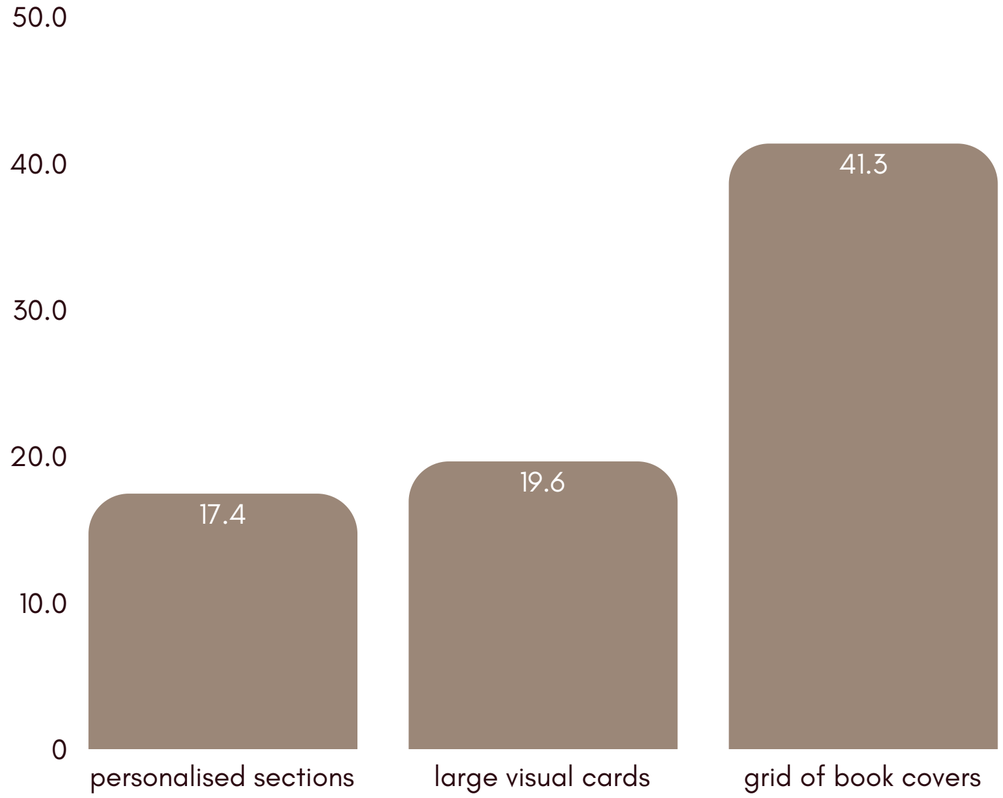
How Readers Want to Discover Books

goodreads

Primary Discovery Channels (n=51)



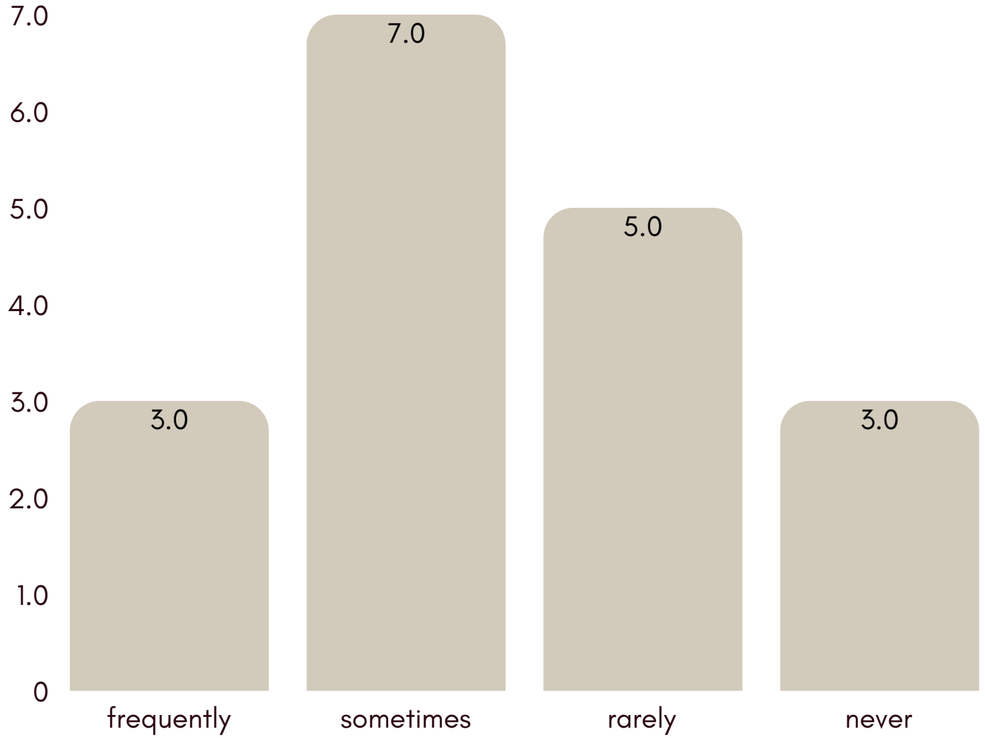
Preferred Recommendation Display (n=51)



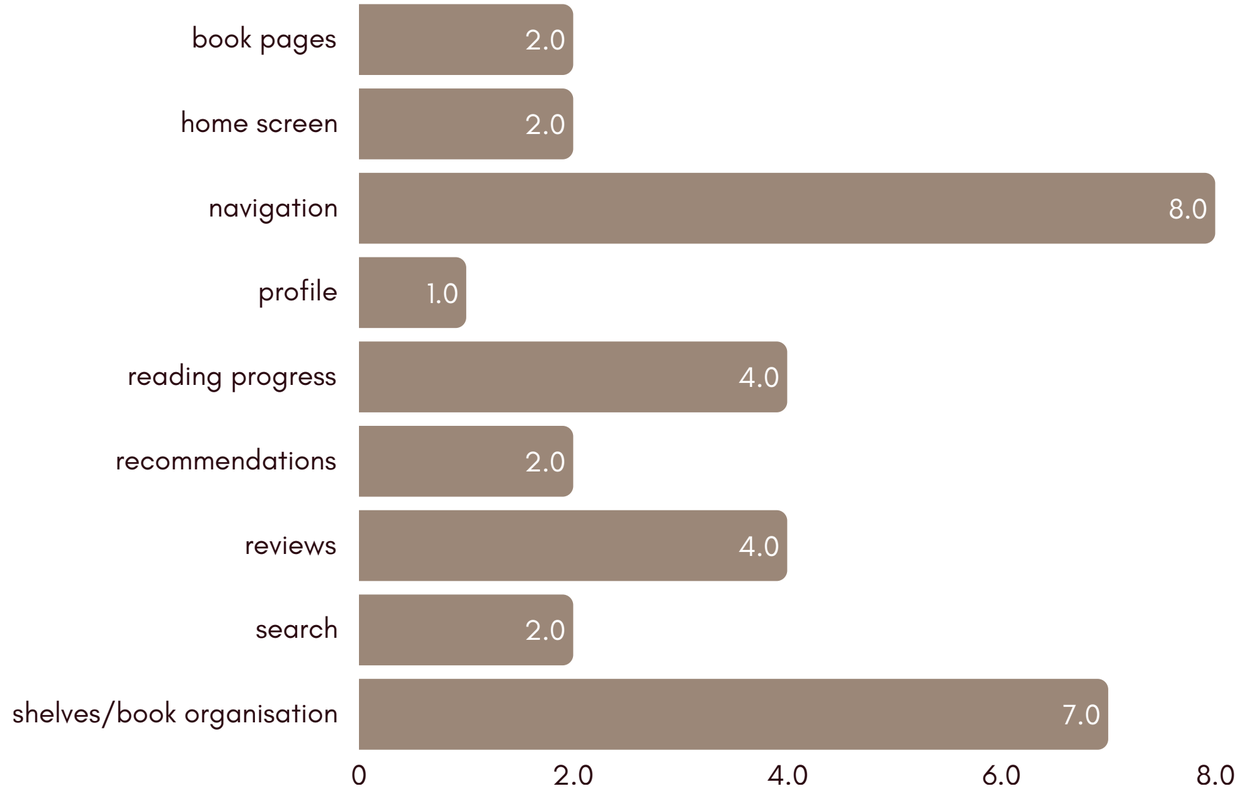
Frustrations of the Users

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How frequently users struggle to find features on goodreads

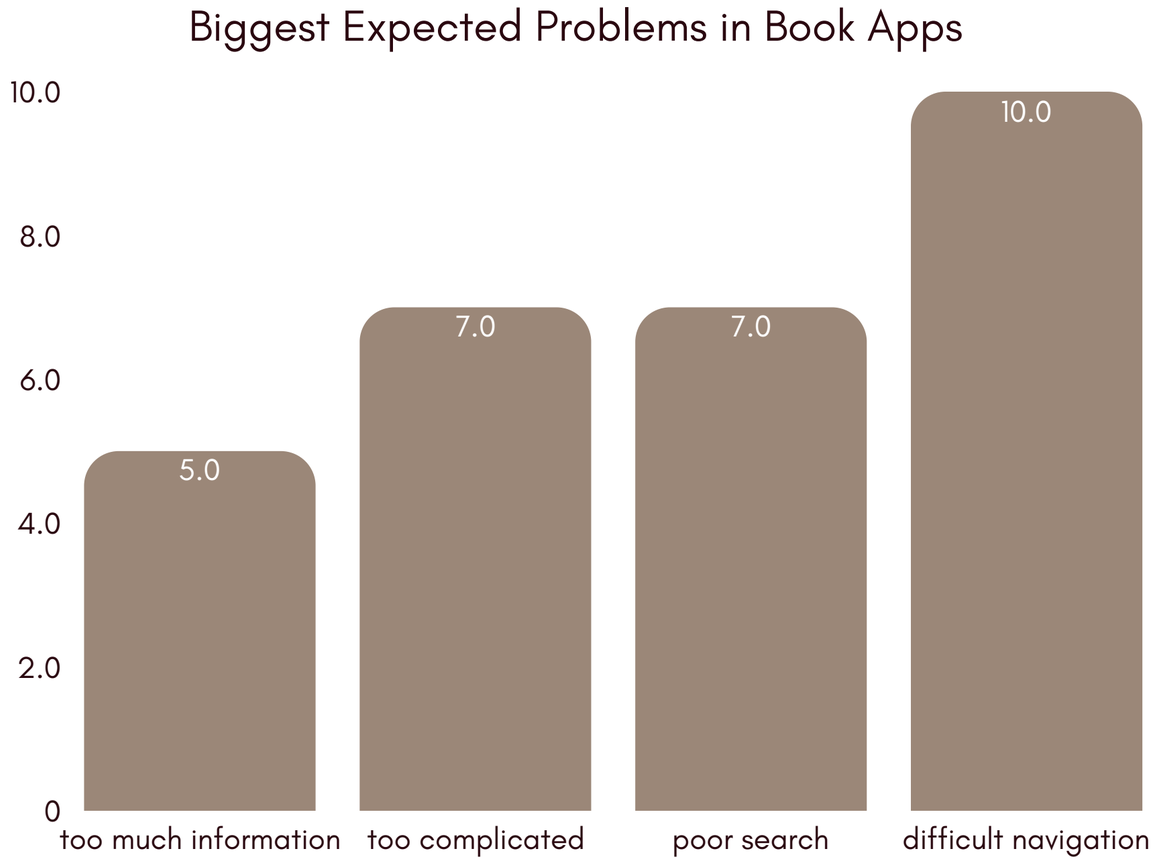


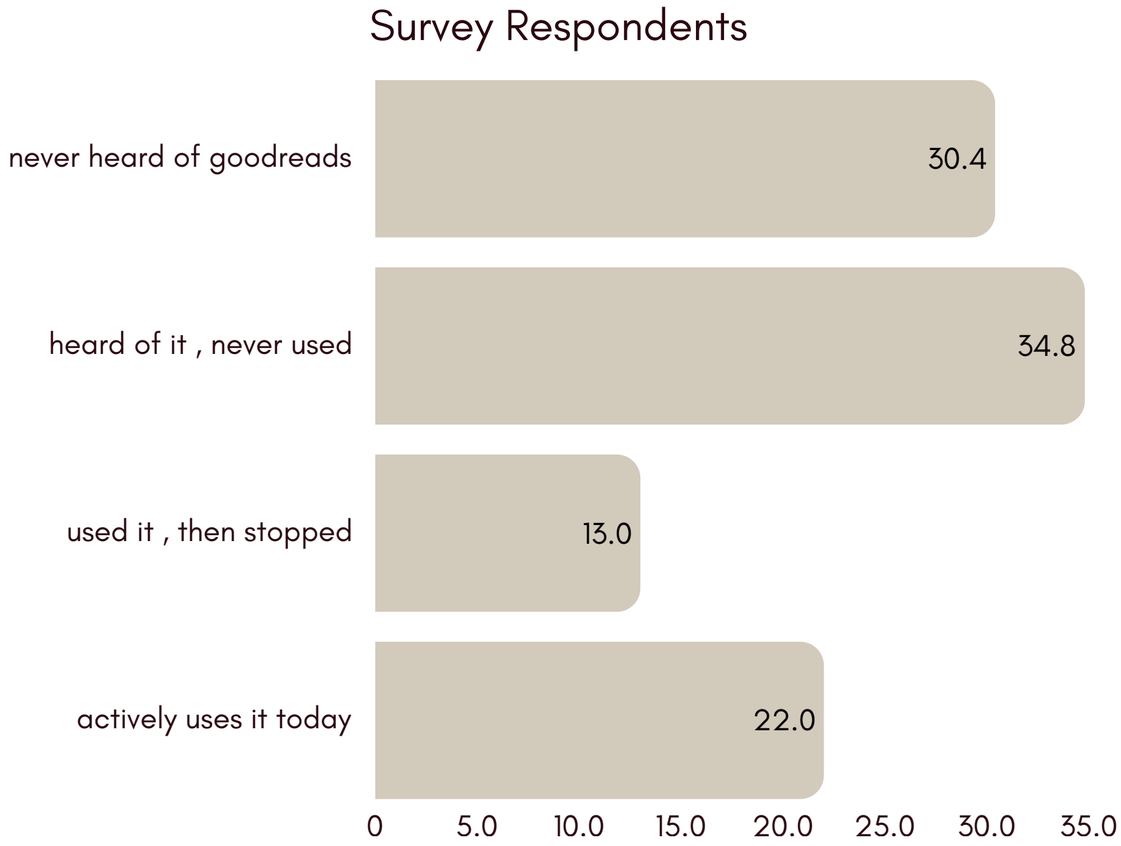
Most confusing or difficult app areas in goodreads



Expected Problems & Goodreads Gaps

goodreads





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User Interviews

Five follow-up conversations that put a human voice behind the survey numbers

Interview Approach

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To add narrative depth to the survey, we conducted 5 follow-up interviews with participants selected to represent the range of reader types and Goodreads familiarity seen in the wider sample — from avid daily readers to people who've never opened the app. Quotes in the next page are composite profiles built directly from patterns in the survey's open-ended answers, used here to make the quantitative findings easier to relate to.

10 min

Average interview length

5

Participants, readers and non-readers

Semi-structured

Format — same 6 prompts, open follow-ups

Meet the Interview Participants

goodreads



Varsha, 21

Student · Regular Reader

Key insight: Book discovery, reviews & reading motivation

I want an easier way to discover new books, with ratings and descriptions. I'd also like a little celebration when I finish reading."

Needs book discovery, useful negative reviews, reminders, and a balance between features and simple navigation.



Thasleema 26

Student · Occasional Reader

Key insight: Search accessibility & simple reading experience

"*I prefer browsing by genre and checking the reviews, but sometimes it's difficult to find the search bar. I want a simple, balanced experience.*"

Needs an easily accessible search bar, synopsis and genre visibility, recent reviews, and gentle reminders rather than constant notifications.



Sadhna, 17

Student · Avid Reader

Key insight: Personalised discovery & transparent reviews

"*I want personalised recommendations and similar-book suggestions, but the interface should stay simple. I also want to understand what readers really think.*"

Needs personalised discovery, plot descriptions, accessible chapter information, negative reviews, and reading progress tracking.



Malavika, 32

Working Professional · Avid Reader

Key insight: Library management, navigation & social features

"*I like an app that makes managing my books fun, with scanning, customisable shelves and reading stats. But everything needs to be easy to find.*"

Needs quick book scanning, clear information hierarchy, simple navigation, customisable reading shelves, and social reading features.



Merin

Job-seeking · Not currently reading

Key insight: Rebuilding reading habits & personalised discovery

"I'd come back to reading if an app recommended books based on what I've liked before. I want something simple that helps me get back into the habit.

Needs personalised recommendations, an easy-to-use interface, gentle reading reminders, and relevant book suggestions that make returning to reading feel engaging.

What the Conversations Confirmed

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1 Simple navigation matters

Participants preferred a balance of features and simplicity. Difficult navigation and hidden functions can make basic actions harder to access.

2 Discovery needing more context

Descriptions, genres, ratings, and personalised recommendations help readers decide which books to explore, rather than relying on a title alone.

3 Beyonds Recommendations

Readers showed interest in recent, negative, and varied reviews. The interviews suggest that readers want more than just an overall rating when evaluating a book.

4 Effortless library management

Features such as wishlists, book scanning, reading shelves, and easy access to saved books support how readers organise their reading experience.

5 Different Review Perspectives

Readers showed interest in recent, negative, and varied reviews. The interviews suggest that readers want more than just an overall rating when evaluating a book.

These insights are based on the four interviews you shared. Merin's persona is hypothetical, so her needs should be treated as a design hypothesis rather than a confirmed interview finding.

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Painpoints & Insights

Three findings, each triangulated across secondary research, survey data and interviews

Goodreads User Pain Points

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- Difficult Navigation – Key features like friends, communities, books and quotes are hard to find.
- Weak Community – Users struggle to discover and engage with relevant communities.
- Poor Progress Tracking – Users want easier daily page tracking, goals and accountability.
- Limited Personalisation – Recommendations should better reflect users' reading history and interests.
- Limited Challenges – Users want monthly challenges, friend participation and accountability.
- No Private Notes – Users need a space for personal book notes without public reviews.
- Difficult Book Cataloguing – Users want an easier, shareable digital library for organising books.
- Hidden Quotes – The Quotes feature is difficult to discover, pushing users toward the web version.

Insights

1 Readers Demand Minimalist, High-Hierarchy Interfaces

Across the survey, interviews and secondary research alike, the loudest and most consistent signal is a demand for restraint: fewer competing elements, a clear reading order, and visuals (covers) doing more of the communicating than text.

78.2%
rate readability as highly important (4–5 of 5)

41.3%
prefer a grid of book covers over lists or text

2 Trust Is Earned Through Personal Relevance, Not Popularity

Popular lists and star ratings aren't enough to build trust. Readers respond better to personalised recommendations based on what they've read, liked, or are in the mood for.

28.3%
trust recommendations based on their own reading

2.2%
trust "popular / trending" books alone

3 Goodreads Has an Awareness-to-Usage Gap, Not a Brand Problem

Goodreads is well-known, but usability remains a challenge. 81.3% of users struggled to find features, while icon and label clarity scored only 2.9/5, showing that unclear navigation can make the app harder to use.

69.6%
recognise the Goodreads brand

21.7%
actually use it actively today

4 Consistency & Clarity Build a Smoother Reading Experience

Readers need an interface that feels predictable, readable and easy to understand across every page. Consistent layouts, clearer interactions and better visual feedback can reduce confusion and make the experience feel more effortless.

78.2%
rate readability as highly important (4–5 of 5)

75%
report difficulty finding or navigating certain features

goodreads

Target Audience & Segments

Who this redesign needs to work for, and the three behavioural groups within that audience

Primary Target User

goodreads

16–35 Age group

TARGET AUDIENCE

PROFILE

- Primarily 16–35 years old
- Mostly students and young working professionals
- Reads weekly to daily
- Mixes physical books and digital reading
- Uses book platforms to discover, track, save and review books
- Wants a simple, visually appealing, easy-to-navigate interface
- Values readability, visual hierarchy and consistent UI
- Expects better personalised recommendations and search/filtering



69.2%
Are students

30.8%
Are working professionals

Three Types of Users

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Users were grouped into three categories based on their familiarity and usage of Goodreads, helping us compare different experiences, needs, and pain points across the platform.

01



The Book Explorer

~49%

Main goal: discover what to read next. Motivated by mood, genre and personalised discovery over static lists.

02



The Reading Tracker

~34%

Main goal: keep track of their reading life. Wants stats, progress, customisable dashboards and clean organisation.

03



The Casual / Potential Reader

~17%

Main goal: find something interesting without committing to a complicated system. Needs low-friction, high-personalisation onboarding.

goodreads

Personas & Empathy Maps

Three user types brought to life, each paired with an empathy map to guide design decisions

Persona 01 Merin John



Merin John

16 · School Student · New to Reading

THE FIRST-TIME READER

“I don't need a system — I need something to tell me what to read next, right now.”

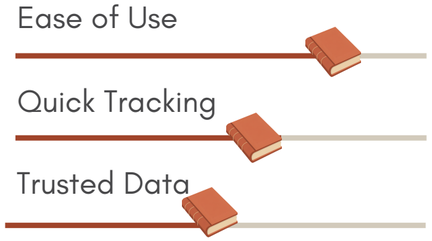
WHO THEY ARE

Merin is a 16-year-old high school student who has recently started getting into reading. She mostly picks up young adult fiction, romance and fantasy after seeing books on Instagram, TikTok or through friends. She uses Goodreads occasionally, mainly when she wants to see what a book is about or find something similar to what she already likes.

WANTS TO SEE

- Easy recommendations for someone new to reading
- Simple, beginner-friendly interface
- Attractive and visual book covers
- Short, easy-to-understand reviews

MOTIVATIONS



GOALS

- Find books that are easy and enjoyable to get into
- Discover new authors and genres
- Know what other young readers are enjoying
- Slowly build her own reading list
- Keep track of the books she finishes

FRUSTRATIONS

- Doesn't know where to start when there are too many books
- Finds some recommendations too advanced or unrelated to her interests
- Doesn't always understand long or detailed reviews
- Gets distracted by irrelevant content and ads

SAYS

- “Is this book actually good?”
- “I wish I could just see recommendations I’d like.”
- “Why is this so confusing?”
- “I want something fun and easy to use.”

THINKS

- Curious about different genres and authors
- Excited when she finds a book that matches her interests
- Overwhelmed when there are too many choices
- Wants recommendations that feel relevant to her age



Merin John

THE FIRST-TIME READER

DOES

- Saves books she sees on Instagram or TikTok
- Asks friends for recommendations
- Looks at book covers before deciding
- Searches for books based on mood or genre

FEELS

- Confused when the app feels complicated
- Unsure about what to pick
- Motivated when recommendations feel personal
- A little intimidated by being new to reading

Persona 02 — Ananya Rao



Ananya Rao

21 · University Student · Occasional Reader

THE BOOK EXPLORER

"I don't need a system — I need something to tell me what to read next, right now."

WHO THEY ARE

Ananya reads a few times a month between classes, mostly discovering books through Instagram and friends. She's tried Goodreads but found it overwhelming and rarely opens it after the first week. She wants a book app to feel like a discovery tool, not a chore.

WANTS TO SEE

- Grid of book covers, not text lists
- Mood- and genre-based browsing
- Personalised "for you" sections
- Clean, uncluttered book detail pages

MOTIVATIONS

Ease of Use

Quick Tracking

Trusted Data

GOALS

- Find her next read in under a minute
- Discover books that match her current mood
- Feel confident a recommendation is actually "for her"

FRUSTRATIONS

- Endless scrolling through generic star-rated lists
- Cluttered pages that bury the book cover under metadata
- Recommendations that ignore what she's already liked

SAYS

- “What should I read next?”
- “This app is so cluttered.”
- “Why does this look like a spreadsheet?”

THINKS

- Wonders if the recommendation is genuinely for her or just popular
- Assumes a clean app is a trustworthy app
- Worries she'll pick the “wrong” next book and lose momentum



Ananya Rao

THE BOOK EXPLORER

DOES

- Scrolls Instagram and BookTok for recommendations
- Opens a book app, browses a few covers, closes it
- Rarely finishes onboarding flows or long forms

FEELS

- Overwhelmed by dense, text-heavy screens
- Delighted by a well-curated, visual recommendation
- Frustrated when search returns irrelevant results

Persona 03 — Afreen Sayed



Afreen Sayed

26 · Between Jobs · Not Currently Reading

THE CASUAL / POTENTIAL READER

"I'd read more if something actually knew what I'd like."

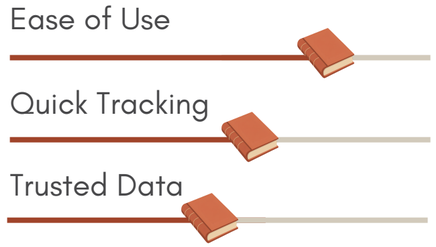
WHO THEY ARE

Ayesha isn't currently reading much but isn't opposed to starting again. She's never used Goodreads and finds book-tracking apps intimidating — shelves, challenges and stats feel like commitments she isn't ready for. What would draw her in is a low-pressure way to find one good book based on things she's already enjoyed.

WANTS TO SEE

- A no-pressure "start here" recommendation flow
- Recommendations based on movies/shows or past favourites
- Simple, encouraging progress — not competitive challenges
- Easy search with good reviews visible upfront

MOTIVATIONS



GOALS

- Find one genuinely interesting book without setting up a whole system
- Get recommendations based on personal taste, not popularity
- Ease into reading without feeling like she's behind on a challenge

FRUSTRATIONS

- Onboarding that asks for shelves and goals before she's read anything
- Feeling like everyone else is more "serious" about reading than she is
- Recommendation lists that feel generic or ad-driven

SAYS

- “I don't really read but I want to get back into it.”
- “This feels like homework.”
- “Just tell me one good book to start with.”

THINKS

- Feels behind compared to “serious” readers she sees online
- Assumes tracking apps are for people who already read a lot
- Believes a good first recommendation could reignite the habit



Ayesha Khan

THE CASUAL / POTENTIAL READER

DOES

- Browses bookstores occasionally without buying
- Follows a few BookTok/Bookstagram accounts passively
- Has downloaded and deleted book apps before finishing setup

FEELS

- Intimidated by shelves, challenges and stats on first open
- Encouraged by simple, low-commitment recommendations
- Hopeful that the right app could bring reading back into her life

Persona 04 — Joseph Kurian



Joseph Kurian

32 · Working Professional · Avid Reader

THE READING TRACKER

"I've read for years — let me see the shape of my reading life, my way."

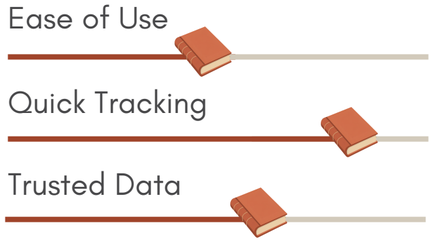
WHO THEY ARE

Kabir reads daily and has used Goodreads for over a decade. He knows the platform's quirks well and has strong opinions about how it could be better organised. He wants his dashboard, stats and shelves front and centre — and he's frustrated that reviews are sorted in a way that surfaces negativity over usefulness.

WANTS TO SEE

- Customisable dashboard widgets
- Detailed reading stats and yearly trends
- Filterable, sortable review threads
- Faster sync between devices

MOTIVATIONS



GOALS

- Customise his home screen to show what matters to him
- See detailed, long-term reading statistics
- Sort and filter reviews by relevance, not just "most liked"

FRUSTRATIONS

- Reviews sorted by likes surface harsh takes first
- No way to bulk-edit or reorganise a large reading history
- Feature parity gaps between the mobile app and the website

SAYS

- “Why can't I sort these reviews properly?”
- “I just want my stats front and centre.”
- “The app and website don't even match.”

THINKS

- Believes he's outgrown the default layout after years of use
- Thinks a power-user mode shouldn't be this hard to ask for
- Assumes better organisation would deepen his loyalty to the app



Joseph Kurian

THE READING TRACKER

DOES

- Logs every book the day he finishes it
- Edits shelves and tags from the desktop site out of habit
- Checks yearly reading-challenge progress often

FEELS

- Mildly frustrated by rigid, one-size-fits-all layouts
- Proud of his long reading history and stats
- Irritated when negative reviews dominate a book he loves

Conclusion

Where the Goodreads redesign should focus first, based on the findings from this research

Design Priorities for the Redesign

1 Simplify the book detail page

Prioritise the essentials — cover, title, author, rating and a short description. Move secondary metadata, links and promotional content lower on the page.

2 Make discovery visual & personal

Use a visual grid of book covers and personalise recommendations around mood, genre, reading history and interests rather than relying mainly on popularity.

3 Simplify navigation & search

Make the most-used features easy to reach. Improve search, reduce unnecessary navigation steps and create a clearer, more predictable structure.

4 Give users more control

Let readers customise their home experience, organise shelves, filter reviews and choose how information is displayed across the platform.

5 Create a low-pressure onboarding

Don't overwhelm new or casual readers with setup. Start with a few simple preferences and immediately offer relevant recommendations before asking for more information.

6 Improve consistency & everyday usability

Create a consistent visual system across pages and devices, while addressing small but frequent frustrations such as readability, dark mode and unclear interactions.

Thank You